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Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 655 April 2003 PO BOX 1628, WELLINGTON

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first clear Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings, run with an iron fist jam by El Presidente Alan Lowrie, start with precision at 8.00 pm with club business. Talks kick-off on the button at 8.01 pm.

Section night & AGM, Monday 7th April, 8 pm at Turnbull House: Richard Wesley will talk on...

Ice Age Facing Frostbite, Forced Bivies and Deportation on Mt Logan

Richard Wesley and Keith Parks set off to climb Mt St Elias, Alaska and found themselves instead on top of Mt Logan, Canada, the second highest peak in North America. Come along and experience the whole story of huge glaciers, unforgiving mountains and boarder crossing antics.

As a bribe to get everyone along to this months section night we have sample packs of HEARDS Barley Sugars to give away to club members just for being there.

This club wants you: AGM coming on 7th of April!

Well, the AGM is on the 7th of April at 8 pm at Turnbull House on Bowen Street. It is always short, sweet, and as non-bureaucratic as possible.

This is your chance, we are always looking for keen enthusiastic volunteers to be on the Wellington Section Committee. Nominations are now open for Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer, Section Representative (to attend twice yearly Club Committee meetings in Christchurch) and Committee Members. Feel free to nominate yourself



in Christchurch) and Committee Members. Feel free to nominate yourself or someone else by contacting Alan, email chairperson@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or phone 025 653 1082 now or come along to the AGM. If you would like to know what we get up to, have a read of the Annual Report, Financial Statements, 2002 AGM Minutes and newsletters on our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or talk to any current committee member.

Vertigo thanks Al Lowrie

Al Lowrie is stepping down as President after the AGM. Vertigo wants to say thanks for all the hard work on behalf of Wellington section members Al!

Cheap climbing at Fergs

As an Alpine Club member you can now climb at Fergs Rock and Kayak for only \$5 EVERY Monday night, and at any other time for only \$8 (usually \$12). Make sure you carry your card and that your membership is up to date.

Our website

Reminder about our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz. Over half of Wellington section members are now subscribed to our free email discussion group. If you would like to get or communicate information of interest then go to our web site www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz for instructions on how to join.

NZAC Governance

Your Club Committee is looking at how the NZAC is being run. If you have comments on the current set up or suggestions to improve it then please let one of your National Reps know.

Contact either Caroline (cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) or Maria (mc@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Distaghil Sar Fund Applications

This fund was set up as a memorial to Chris Hoare, Andy Boas and Steve Thornley, Wellington Section members who died on Distaghil Sar in the Karakoram in August 1996.

The fund is made up of donations from families and friends. Awards are made every year from the interest it earns. This year the total available for awards (including interest not spent last year) is in the region of \$1000. The purpose of the fund is to assist members to become better qualified to instruct on our alpine courses.

Any member of the section may apply for an award. The closing date for applications this year is 2 May. Decisions about grants are made by the fund administrators (the section's chairperson, instruction committee convener and treasurer).

Applications should be in writing, and should specify the courses or qualifications for which financial assistance is sought; the need for such assistance; and the availability of the applicant to instruct on the section's snow courses.

Appropriate courses are NZAC or FMC instructor courses; NZOIA snow assessments or pre-assessments; risk assessment and outdoor first aid courses; or any other courses or qualifications that the fund administrators approve. Awards will be used to pay for expenses actually incurred, rather than given as a lump sum.

The decision about awards will take into account the applicants' climbing skills and judgement, ability to communicate with students, commitment to safety, previous contributions to the section's instruction programmes, and availability to instruct on the section's alpine courses in future. The available funding may be given to one applicant, or split between two or more.

Applications should be sent to Distaghil Sar Fund, NZAC Wellington Section, PO Box 1628, Wellington BY 2 MAY 2003. Awards will be announced in the June newsletter.



Moved House?

Please notify the Club's National Administrator of your change of address as the labels for all newsletters and club publications are generated at the HQ office.

You can contact:

Richard Wesley
NZAC Administrator
PO BOX 786
CHRISTCHURCH
TEL (03) 377 7595

FAX (03) 337 7594
e mail office@alpineclub.org.nz



Section news: Sharing and growing!

Please send your trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz so everyone can enjoy your stories, tall or short.

Summer Rock course 2003

“See if you can get your hand into that crack.”

“Pretend you have a 5 cent piece between your butt cheeks. Squeeze!”

“This will be a good smear test for you.”

Instructor demonstrating lead belaying to the students: “when you’re lead belaying, it’s very important psychologically to offer the leader lots of positive reinforcement about his climbing.”

Unnamed student’s follow up to Matt, then about to demonstrate how to lead a climb: “Matt, your butt looks fantastic in that harness”.

And that’s just a small sample of the dubious comments heard from on this year’s Summer Rock course.

After our introductory sessions in Ferg’s we were introduced to natural rock at Baring Head. Fingers were jammed into Whale Rock and hips were bent into new positions to bridge up the Slot. I soon discovered that there’s nothing like a few metres of air beneath your feet to focus the mind.

Despite assurances that the sand at Baring Head was cushion-soft, it was a relief to get into roped climbs at Titahi Bay. It was another day of sunshine, and maybe it was the heat that turned our instructors into belay Nazis. They paced up and down at the bottom of the Slab shouting “Pull! Lock! Under grip! Slide!” Our efforts were rewarded by fun climbing with maximum friction to test our feet, excellent views from the top and a chance to try out abseiling.

Our next lesson was to be endurance, in the form of a six-hour drive to Wharepapa. “This is insane,” I thought - until I saw the rock at Froggatt Edge. A weird collection of rocks in the middle of a cluster of fields, Froggatt Edge offered us a wide range of climbs clustered in a small area.

Students pottering on the short, easy climbs of Honeycomb Wall could hear the cries of pain and frustration from next door's aptly named Bring your Daughter to the Slaughter.

For the final weekend of the course we went north again to Kinloch, on the shores of Lake Taupo. The main focus of the weekend was on setting up anchors. Concentration levels were high, especially when we realised that we had to test our anchors by using them to abseil down the crag. We also got an introduction to lead climbing and a chance to prussic up a tree.

Scott had already impressed us with his culinary skills at Wharepapa, but this time he took it to another level, feeding us with giant steaks barbecued to order. I would suggest one improvement for next year's course though: his guacamole recipe should be included in the training manual. The course ended with a swim in Lake Taupo. Chilly? Maybe, but it was nothing to the red-hot climbers that we had become through the hard work of our instructors.

Thanks to Sheila Ryan

Expeditions

A team, mainly from Wellington section, was fortunate in getting through to the final four in the SPARC Hillary Grant process. Though missing the final cut, Steve Hart has amassed a fair bit of information on expedition matters, including some excellent stuff on medical issues. So if you need help, advice or just contact information for an expedition to Nepal then get in touch with Steve, contact details at the back of Vertigo.

Steve

Weather or not

"February", Geoff Spearpoint aka Mr New Zealand High Country (NZAC Canterbury/Westland) said, "gives stable settled weather with the occasional short lasting weak low". This convinced myself, Eric Duggan (NZAC Wellington) and Jonathan Kennett (Kennett Bros) to join him on a transalpine trip along the Lord Range hopefully sneaking up Mt Whitcombe and Dan Peak on the way. After the third night of severe wind, rain, snow, thunder and lightening, during which our Macpac alpine Minaret tents proved their worth, we decided to escape from our camp only 350 metres below the summit of Snowdome. What had been an interesting romp up through rock bluffs now became an extremely rigorous test of our outdoor abilities: navigating in whiteout over glaciers; down climbing frozen rock; ploughing through deep snow drifts and struggling to stand in the same wind gusts which allegedly picked up a Hokitika pet dog and deposited it two km away.



We all relished the experience in conditions that did not leave much margin for error and tested our skills and teamwork. I know exactly why “Mr NZ High Country” doesn’t put his feet up in front of the fire at the mere hint of a dodgy weather forecast.

Johnny Mulheron

And here are the club trips for 2003...

Easter 2003 18th to 27th April 2003 - Wilkin Valley Exploration

Easter Weekend and ANZAC day = only 3 days leave for 9 days away!

There are a host of peaks around the area to satisfy a range of skills. The Wilkin Valley is in Aspiring National Park. Objectives could include Castor, Pollux, Alba. Easy tramping is available. Please show your interest early, because transport booking has to be made well in advance. Contact: Don French don.f@xtra.co.nz, phone: 06 377 7117

Nelson Lakes National Park, Friday 30 May - Monday 2 June

The aim is Mt Hopeless (2278m). There is also the possibility of taking the Friday off work and aiming for Mt Travers(2338m) and/or Mt Cupola(2260m) as well. If you're keen to join me email cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, ph: 475 5542

Queens Birthday Weekend 2003 - The Inland Kaikouras

A chance to taste early winter snow in the inland Kaiakouras. Kevin Patterson is planning to get to Tapeaonuku next June. To get in quick with your place contact him at: Kevin.Patterson@nzmp.com, ph:04 566 0975

Post Monsoon 2004 (September/October)

How about a slightly longer trip - to Nepal? Several people have indicated interest in a section climbing trip to attempt several trekking peaks, Island Peak and Lobuje East have been suggested as reasonably straightforward objectives. This could include a non-climbing trek party also. Trip leaders for both are emerging as discussions go on. To indicate an initial interest email the trip co-ordinator, trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.

Other Sections trips

Don't forget there are other sections of the NZAC out there. Check out there trips by going onto the main website www.nzalpine.org.nz and clicking on the individual section newsletters.

Thanks to everyone making an effort to generate club trips. Remember, trips can be any length, any level of difficulty and any size (a trip of two people is just as valid as a trip of ten - but can you take a trip by yourself? Ed.) We have a trip template and plenty of suggestions for those who want to give it a go. Do contact me even if you want ideas for private trips. Nothing will be set in stone! sh@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, or phone 04-9738079